interesting: probably, the company wanted him out of the way before the shareholders' meeting.

As we noted in the last chapter, VOC's employment in the company had continued even after the showdown in the first week of March. Following his defenestration as assistant secretary, a statutory post, he had been made 'an agent' sometime in February 1908—'he is now a servant under the Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company', as K.R. Guruswami Aiyar had noted with satisfaction.[12] This too was not to the company's complete satisfaction but VOC had refused to resign under duress on 7 March 1908. That VOC's name continued to remain on the employment rolls, even if it was only nominal since he was in prison, came up when the Tirunelveli deputation met the governor (on 1 April) who had pointedly raised the status of VOC in the company. K.R. Guruswami Aiyar had clarified: 'He is still an employee, but only he has not been able to do any work after that order that was passed on the 8th March. After the passing of that order, he went away and he has not turned up. We have not been able to take any action, because he has not come back to us.'[13] The strange way in which Guruswami Aiyar alludes to VOC's arrest apart, it is clear that the cabal under him would not rest until VOC was thrown out of the company. Guruswami Aiyar had stated emphatically to the governor that,

> Time has come when we should get rid of him. The outside public cannot complain if he is got rid of. The directors have been waiting for an opportunity. Other reasons weigh with them and therefore they waited for an opportunity. If he is dismissed, *as he will be*, he owes it to himself. There will be no feeling which will prejudice the further working of the company.[14]

We do not know how Guruswami Aiyar manoeuvred it, but in the first week of June, VOC resigned 'in the best interests of the company'. In doing so, he earnestly appealed to the patriotism of the directors and his countrymen at large.[15]

> Dear Brothers,